relay hunger strike to get their demand fulfilled.

The courts thus remained paralysed. On 17 February, the Tees Hazari courts complex witnessed an unprecedented riot. People from distant places such as Samaypur and Badli (on the outskirts of Delhi) and also from adjoining areas came in trucks and tempos to protest against what they considered to be an unlawful and baseless strike. They raised slogans against the striking lawyers. The lawyers formed an opposition group immediately and slanging matches and brickbatting became the order of the day. In the ensuing melee several persons (belonging to both groups) as well as bystanders were injured. The police had to intervene to separate the groups and restore order. A number of arrests were made, the most prominent being that of a Delhi municipal councillor, Rajesh Yadav.

Such a situation naturally stoked the fire of the lawyers' agitation. They were quick to scream themselves hoarse that Kiran Bedi had engineered the whole scenario and declared that they would stop short of nothing but her 'blood'!

The interesting thing about the whole episode was that the lawyers themselves were divided about the course of events. Almost all the senior lawyers of the Supreme Court as well as the Delhi High Court were strongly opposed to the strike, whereas the junior lawyers were adamant that they would not rest till Kiran Bedi was dismissed. The senior lawyers insisted that a secret ballot be held to determine the true opinion of the majority regarding the continuation of the strike. Under vehement protests and demonstrations such a secret ballot was held in the premises of the Supreme Court Bar Association Library. Govinda Mukhoty, the president of the Delhi Bar Association Action Committee, assured one and all that there would be no force used during the balloting and that if there was, then, he would resign from his post. Ballot boxes, however, were hijacked. The Supreme Court Bar Association president, M. C. Bhandare, condemned this hijacking and declared it to be highly undemocratic and an act of cowardice. 'Those who fight for human rights should see to it that others' right to vote should not be frustrated. The silent majority of the Supreme Court has decided to lift the siege from 7 March,' he declared.

If telling evidence of hijacking were needed, the photographs published in some newspapers showed a group of lawyers carrying away ballot boxes from the Supreme Court premises. Prominent among them were the president of the New Delhi Bar Association, Thakur Onkar Singh, and Rajesh Wadhwa, a member of the New Delhi Bar Association. The two, however, denied that the pictures were theirs but admitted that they did have a remarkable resemblance. Govinda Mukhoty stated that there was 90 per cent evidence of his 'boys' having been involved in the ballot-box hijacking and in the general disruption caused to the voting process but maintained that as there was still a margin of 10 per cent proof of certainty, he would not resign. Later, however, he changed his stance and said he would resign. This was enough to drive the chairman of the Delhi Bar Association, Daljit Tandon, to tears and declare that once again money power and adverse publicity were out to stifle their efforts.

In another significant development, a lawyers' delegation approached Union Home Minister Buta Singh and demanded the suspension of Kiran Bedi. The home minister rejected their appeal and requested them to call off their stir pending the report of the high-powered commission that was looking into the matter. While the striking lawyers then demonstrated against the home minister, women's rights activists, women's groups and university students held a massive rally to support Buta Singh's statement.

While the lawyers in Delhi continued their agitation, several high courts across the country condemned it and declared it to be illegal. They maintained that such gross dereliction of duty should be severely punished. They declared that lawyers had made it a habit of striking work on the flimsiest of pretexts without any responsibility towards their commitments, leading to the harassment of the